from China or to settle the territorial disputes with China by Indian land-grabs. Nevertheless, Beijing clearly saw matters differently. In response to the Forward Policy, Chinese patrolling grew even more aggressive in Ladakh. Indian and Chinese posts were engaged in a higgledy-piggledy set of deployments – side by side, facing each other, threatening lines of communication. The Chinese advanced on Indian posts in Chip Chap and Galwan but then withdrew in May and June 1962. Fighting broke out in various places in the western sector, and the Indian Army was authorized to fire if Chinese troops got too close. When on 8 September the Chinese occupied the Dhola-Thagla ridge in the eastern sector, a decision was made to evict them. Before Indian troops could do so, the Chinese started a firefight on 20 September. On 10 October, India was caught off guard when the Chinese launched an attack in the Thagla area at Tseng Jong – some eight hundred Chinese troops against just fifty Indian defenders. Just before he left for a trip to Ceylon (now Sri Lanka), Nehru stated publicly that he had ordered the army to recover Indian territory lost in the eastern sector. Even as the Indians planned their next move in the Thagla area, China went to full-scale war on 20 October.

A mainstream Indian view is that China was determined to attack and humiliate India. Going by the fateful meeting of the Chinese leadership on 6 October, that is correct: Mao wanted India to be hit hard and hit where it hurt most, that is, the eastern sector where the Indian Army was strongest, so that it would be clear that India had been taught a lesson. Before that, however, both sides had advanced a series of proposals to stabilize the situation.

In September 1959, at an internal meeting Mao proposed that both sides withdraw twenty kilometres from their confrontational positions at the time. If India rejected this, he told his decision-making team, China should withdraw anyway and stop forward patrolling.[69] After Longju, as noted earlier, India withdrew its troops from Tamaden. When China publicly suggested in November 1959 that both sides withdraw twenty kilometres from their respective control lines and stop forward patrolling, India agreed that the latter was a positive step. However, a symmetric pullback, as